

Core Rules

CORE RULES

How the game works. Start here.

Core Resolution

CORE RESOLUTION

Diaphragma uses one die: a **d10**.

Not every action needs a roll. If there is nothing pushing back the action simply succeeds. If failure is certain regardless of effort, it simply fails. You only roll when the outcome is genuinely uncertain, when something in the fiction is pushing back, when there is a real cost if things go wrong.

WHEN TO ROLL

Roll when there is active opposition, a real chance of failure, or a meaningful cost if things go wrong.

No roll needed when the character is clearly capable and nothing is pushing back. It just happens.

No roll possible when failure is already certain. The fiction decides, the die does not.

When a roll is called for, the player either **Settles** or **Rolls**.

SETTLE

Skip the roll. Your raw result is **5**. But you can never critically succeed or fail.

ROLL

Roll **1d10**. The number on the die is your raw result. Risk and reward both go up.

RESULT TIERS

After all Edges and Bains are applied:

RESULT	OUTCOME
Natural 1	Critical Failure
2 – 6	Failure
7 – 9	Partial Success
10+	Success
Natural 10	Critical Success

CRITICALS

Criticals only come from the **natural die result**.

NATURAL 1

Always a **Critical Failure**, no Edges can prevent it.

NATURAL 10

Critical Success, but only if no relevant Burden blocks success.

Resolution Procedure

RESOLUTION PROCEDURE

- 1 Describe what you want and **how** you do it.
The Storyteller confirms the action is possible and declares any relevant **Burden**.
- 2 The table identifies **Edges** (+1 each) and **Bains** (-1 each).
Settle (result = 5) or **Roll** (1d10). Apply
- 3 Edges and Bains. A Burden caps the result at 9.
- 4 The Storyteller calls the outcome and advances the fiction.
- 5

CRITICAL FAILURE

Only on a natural 1. Something goes badly wrong beyond the action itself. The player is encouraged to narrate what happens, own the failure and make it dramatic!

FAILURE

Result of 2–6. The fiction does not move in your favor. The Storyteller describes what holds.

PARTIAL SUCCESS

Result of 7–9. The fiction move in your favor, but at a cost. The Storyteller adds a complication, pressure, or price.

SUCCESS

Result of 10+. Clean outcome. You get exactly what you wanted with no cost or complication attached.

CRITICAL SUCCESS

Only on a natural 10. You get what you wanted and something extra. The player is encouraged to narrate the moment, own the success and describe how it lands and what it means.



Proficiencies & Specialties

PROFICIENCIES & SPECIALTIES

Characters are defined by what they have **learned, practiced, and lived through**.

PROFICIENCIES

Proficiencies are broad descriptions of what a character is good at, written as lived experience. A Proficiency does not grant a flat bonus. It is fictional license for arguing that an Edge is plausible at all.

I TRAINED AS A SOLDIER

I STUDIED MEDICINE IN WAR CAMPS

I HUNTED BEASTS IN THE MARSH FOR YEARS

I LEARNED TO READ PEOPLE AT COURT

A Proficiency does three things:

- **Gates invocations** — establishes what actions and gear are within your competence.
- **Justifies Edges** — lets you point to your background and say “this covers it.”
- **Anchors Specialties** — it is the container your Specialties hang off of.

INVOKING AT THE TABLE

Player: “I trained as a soldier — I’ve crossed checkpoints like this a hundred times. I know how to look like I belong. That’s my Edge for this roll.”

Player: “I hunted beasts in the marsh for years. I can read how this creature moves. I want to invoke that as an Edge — I know where it’s about to strike before it does.”

SPECIALTIES

Specialties are narrow, concrete focuses that hang off a Proficiency. When a Specialty clearly applies, it contributes **+2**.

PROFICIENCY	SPECIALTY
Trained as a soldier	Rifle marksmanship
Medicine in war camps	Battlefield surgery
Hunted beasts in the marsh	Tracking wetlands

Multiple Specialties can hang off the same Proficiency. This is the intended way to build a character. Pick a few broad Proficiencies, then stack specific Specialties under them.



Edges, Gear & Invoking

EDGES, GEAR & INVOKING

WHAT IS AN EDGE?

An **Edge** is any favorable fictional factor that helps the character. Each Edge is worth **+1** when invoked. Edges may come from gear, allies, position, environment, preparation, information, or enemy weakness.

LOADED REVOLVER +1

HIGH GROUND +1

SILVER CHAIN ALREADY IN HAND +1

ALLY IS PINNING THEM +1

I EXAMINED THE WOUND EARLIER +1

I KNOW THESE WOODS +1

INVOKING

Invoking means calling out an Edge and using it for +1. You may invoke Edges before or after the roll, when Settling or Rolling. There is no limit to the number of Edges you can invoke, even if they grant automatic success.

GEAR

Gear often creates Edges — but not all gear is equal.

USEFUL BY DEFAULT

A lantern in darkness. A rope on a cliff. An explosive against a barricade. Anyone can invoke these.

REQUIRES TRAINING

Guns, complex weapons, technical tools, ritual equipment. Usually needs a relevant Proficiency to invoke effectively.

EDGE ECONOMY

Edges are not just bonuses, they are a measure of how well positioned a character is. A character with three active Edges has options: gear in hand, allies nearby, terrain in their favor. A character with none is exposed, unprepared, and running out of room.

The Storyteller's job is to apply narrative pressure that makes Edges harder to keep. The torch burns out. The ally goes down. You lose the high ground. As Edges disappear, the margin for failure narrows.

EDGES AS CREATIVE PLAY

There is no fixed list of valid Edges. If the fiction supports it and the table agrees, it counts. The player who looks at a scene and asks **“how can I use the darkness, the crowd, the broken pipe above them?”** is playing the game well. Creativity is mechanical advantage.

Edges also function as a health bar. When nothing applies and the roll comes, a Failure is not a minor setback, it is a real cost. Capture. A wound that does not heal. Death. As long as a player can keep Edges in play, the character has footing. Lose them all, and the situation is genuinely dangerous.

Burdens & Bains

BURDENS & BAINS

These are the two main ways the fiction pushes back against the characters.

BURDENS

Burdens are defining flaws. They are not temporary setbacks, they define who the character is.

I FREEZE WHEN FIRE CLOSES IN

I STILL TRUST STEVE TOO MUCH

I CANNOT REFUSE A PUBLIC CHALLENGE

When a Burden applies it must be declared **before** the action is resolved. The action cannot achieve Success or Critical Success, the best possible outcome is **Partial Success**, even if Edges push the result to 10+.

GENERATING NP

If a Burden creates a dramatic moment that advances the story, it may generate **Narrative Points** for the group.

BURDENS VS BAINS

As a Burden: “Broken leg” is a defining lasting limitation. It follows the character everywhere, caps success on relevant actions, and cannot be easily removed.

As a Bain: “Broken leg” is a current condition worth -1 or -2. It can be healed, treated, or removed through play.

BAINS

Bains are active disadvantages that subtract from the final result. Usually temporary, bad positioning, enemy leverage, environmental hazards.

BROKEN LEG

-1

COVERED IN MUD

-1

BLINDED BY SPARKS

-2

MASTER SWORDSMAN'S GUARD

-2

PINNED BEHIND WEAK COVER

-1

Each Bain can normally be invoked **once** per action. The Storyteller invokes Bains at their discretion — when the fiction genuinely supports it, not to pile on.

SEVERITY	PENALTY
Normal	-1
Serious	-2
Extreme	-3

DECLARING BAINS

The Storyteller declares Bains before the player rolls, not after. It does not feel good to think you succeeded only to have a Bain appear and turn it into a failure. Players deserve to make informed choices about whether to Settle or Roll.

That said, players can walk into situations without fully grasping the danger, and sometimes a surprise is the right call if it makes the story genuinely better.

Narrative Points

NARRATIVE POINTS

NARRATIVE POINTS (NP)

NP are a shared player currency. Any NP generated goes into one common pool for the whole group.

Each session begins with a number of NP equal to the **number of players**. This pool resets at the start of every new session.

NP may also be generated during play when:

- A player rolls a **Critical Failure** and narrates it in a unique, story-advancing way
- A player rolls a **Critical Success** and narrates it in a unique, story-advancing way
- A **Burden** is invoked in a way that creates strong narrative momentum

Spending NP, each spend costs 1 NP:

SPEND	EFFECT
Reroll	Reroll a die you just rolled.
Injection	Add a useful fact or detail to the scene.
Flashback	Establish a brief prior preparation or memory.
Help	Give an ally a small immediate advantage.

THE FLOW OF PLAY

NP flows from dramatic moments. Critical rolls, leaned-into Burdens, and bold narration all put currency into the pool. The group decides together how to spend it.

Storyteller: "His eyes move. You have until the waltz ends."



Storyteller: "Ashford is watching you. He knows you're not who you said you were."

Mara's player: "NP spend — Injection. The Countess Vael is at this party. Mara knows her."

Storyteller: "She's by the clock tower stairs."

Mara's player: "I pull Ashford onto the floor and steer him straight toward her. Let him choose which problem matters more."

Plays & Legendary Plays

PLAYS & LEGENDARY PLAYS

PLAYS

Plays are setting specific abilities, powers, maneuvers, or special actions defined by the Framework.

Plays are not intended to grant a flat bonus by themselves. Instead, they:

- Create new fictional possibilities
- Establish new Edges that would not otherwise exist
- Bypass normal limitations
- Introduce costs, conditions, or tradeoffs

I CAN CONTROL FIRE

I CAN SHOOT IN A WHIRLWIND AND HIT EVERYONE NEARBY

I CAN VANISH INTO A CROWD ONCE PER SCENE

The exact wording, costs, and conditions of Plays are defined by the Framework your Storyteller is running.



LEGENDARY PLAYS

Legendary Plays are not chosen at character creation. They begin empty and are **created**

from play, from the moments that become part of the character's legend.

When a player does something truly memorable, effective, or iconic at the table, the Storyteller may offer them the chance to spend 1

Legendary Token to lock that moment in as a permanent ability. This can also be done by the player themselves.

***"The Vasquez Maneuver"** — Dr. Vasquez stabilized a dying colonist while being dragged through knee-deep water. Now, once per session, she can perform emergency treatment under conditions that would normally make it impossible.*

***"Hold the Corridor"** — Sergeant Park held a collapsing bulkhead alone while the team escaped. Now, once per session, when Park declares they will not move, nothing can move them.*

LEGENDARY TOKENS

Each player starts with 2 **Legendary Tokens** for the story or campaign. Tokens may be refreshed at the Storyteller's discretion.

Conflict

CONFLICT

Conflict in Diaphragma covers any situation where opposing forces clash: a negotiation, a chase, a fight, a standoff, a desperate argument. The rules do not change based on the type of conflict. The fiction determines the stakes; the dice resolve the uncertainty.

HOW CONFLICT WORKS

A conflict is a scene with **active opposition**. Something is pushing back and the outcome is not certain. Both sides want something, and at least one side is willing to act to get it.

The Storyteller frames the situation, who is involved, what is at stake, and what success and failure look like for both sides. Then the scene plays out through a series of actions and rolls.

TYPES OF CONFLICT

All conflicts use the same resolution. The fiction changes; the rules do not.

COMBAT

NEGOTIATION / PERSUASION

CHASE / PURSUIT

STANDOFF / INTIMIDATION

SOCIAL MANEUVERING

SABOTAGE / RACE AGAINST TIME

ENDING A CONFLICT

A conflict ends when one side achieves their goal, can no longer act, or chooses to disengage. The Storyteller narrates the outcome based on where the fiction landed, not just the last roll.

THE 10 SECOND CUT

When multiple characters act at the same time, a firefight, a brawl, a chaotic negotiation, the Storyteller **cuts the scene into 10 second moments**.

Each 10 second window is one beat of actions everyone took - one round. Everyone at the table declares what their character does in that window. The Storyteller resolves each action in the order that makes the most fictional sense, then cuts to the next moment.

HOW A MOMENT PLAYS OUT

- 1 The Storyteller describes the current state of the scene.
- 2 Each player declares what their character does in the next 10 seconds.
- 3 The Storyteller calls any Bains. Players identify Edges.
- 4 Rolls are resolved. The fiction advances.
- 5 Cut to the next moment. Repeat until the conflict resolves.

SIMULTANEOUS ACTIONS

Actions within the same 10 second window are considered simultaneous. If two characters are shooting at each other, both rolls happen. A character who goes down in this window still completes their declared action, they land the hit before they drop.

Conflict Clocks

CONFLICT CLOCKS

There are no hit points in Diaphragma. Every conflict, a fight, a chase, a negotiation, a standoff, has a **Clock**: a dial divided into segments. Players fill segments by succeeding. When the clock is full, the conflict resolves in their favor. You are stacking fictional advantages toward resolution.

FILLING THE CLOCK

Each action in a conflict rolls normally. Based on the result, the clock advances:

RESULT	EFFECT
Failure	Fill 0. Storyteller adds pressure or complication.
Partial Success	Fill 1. But the Storyteller adds a cost or twist.
Success	Fill 1. Clean progress.
Critical Success	Fill 2. Describe the moment.

DIFFERENT APPROACHES

The Storyteller can require that **different Proficiencies** contribute before the clock fills, forcing the group to use different characters and approaches rather than repeating the same action. This keeps conflict dynamic and prevents one player from soloing every scene.

CLOCK DIFFICULTY

The number of segments reflects the difficulty of the opposition. The Storyteller sets this before the conflict begins.

TRIVIAL

CAPABLE

DANGEROUS

CLIMACTIC



COUNTER CLOCKS

The Storyteller may also run a **Counter Clock**, the enemy’s own progress. The bomb is ticking. The villain’s ritual is advancing. The alarm is spreading.

If the enemy clock fills before the players’ clock does, the situation turns against them, the conflict ends badly, or escalates to something worse.

EXAMPLE

The players fight a veteran mercenary (8 segment clock). The mercenary’s bodyguard is calling for backup (6 segment counter clock). Every missed roll or failed action ticks the counter clock. Fill the mercenary’s clock before reinforcements arrive.. or deal with both.

Frameworks

FRAMEWORKS

The core rules of Diaphragma ship without a setting. They are a complete engine — resolution, characters, conflict — but they do not tell you what the world looks like, who the enemies are, or what makes this story different from the last one. That is what a **Framework** does.

WHAT IS A FRAMEWORK? —————

A **Framework** is a setting layer that sits on top of the core rules. It defines:

- The **world** — its tone, history, and feel
- **Character options** — what kinds of characters exist
- **Plays** — special abilities, powers, and maneuvers available in this setting
- **Gear** — what equipment means and what it can do
- **Threats** — the enemies, factions, and forces pushing back
- **Special rules** — any mechanics specific to this genre or story

The core rules do not change between Frameworks. The same d10, the same Edges and Bains, the same result tiers. The Framework adds the color, the stakes, and the fiction on top.

SWAPPING FRAMEWORKS —————

Want to run a heist one week and a war story the next? Swap the Framework. The players keep the same rules, learn the new setting, and play. The engine is the same. The game is different.

WHAT PLAYERS SEE —————

Players interact with the Framework through their **Proficiencies**, their **Plays**, and the fictional context of every roll. A soldier in a war Framework and a courier in a city Framework both use the same resolution — but what they can do, what they carry, and what threatens them are entirely different.

WHAT THE STORYTELLER DOES —————

The Storyteller picks a Framework before the first session and shares what players need to know: the setting, what character types are available, and any setting-specific rules. Everything else in this book handles the rest.

NO FRAMEWORK?

You can run Diaphragma without a published Framework — just agree on a setting with your group and define Plays as needed. The core rules are designed to work with any fiction the table agrees on.

